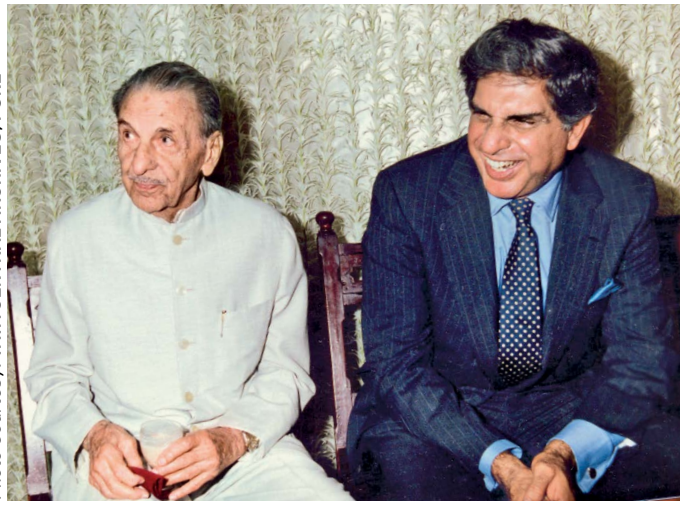


Photo Courtesy: TATA CENTRAL ARCHIVES, PUNE

MENTOR AND GUIDE JRD and Ratan, sometime in the 1980s

The signing took place in Birmingham with Kant, Gandhi and Ramakrishnan representing Tata Motors.

2008 Terror Attack on the Taj

In the meantime, Ratan also got ready to leave for the Taj. Just then, he got a call from Krishna Kumar informing him about the scale of the attack. Ratan reached the Taj around 10.45 pm. When he arrived, there was absolute commotion with terrorists wielding automatic guns and grenades running amok. He too tried making his way into the hotel, but the police, who had arrived by then, prevented him. If anything happened to him, or if he were taken hostage, it would have been the biggest victory for the terrorists...

Recalling that night, Krishna Kumar said in an interview: 'It was a very sad moment for him...for all of us in the group at the senior leadership level, we had a passion for the Taj.... So when that was attacked viciously on 26/11, I think like [mine] his heart broke too...the agony that he felt standing there three days...to see this virtually a temple [sic] go up in flames, in senseless violence, was a revolting sight...our hearts were broken, we had tears in our eyes.'

2009 The Nano

...the car itself took shape during a 'boring' board meeting. When he was bored at long meetings, Ratan would usually preoccupy himself by sketching, drawing and doodling, from which emanated several of his business ideas. As he said at a JRD QV Award function in 2008, he 'spent a lot of time dwelling on how to make the scooter safer, building a frame around it, putting a roof around it'. He added that it was 'perhaps my most constructive doodle' as from that

THE NANO TOOK SHAPE DURING A 'BORING' BOARD MEETING. TATA SPENT A LOT OF TIME DWELLING ON HOW TO MAKE THE SCOOTER SAFER, BUILD A FRAME AND A ROOF AROUND IT

germinated the idea of the Nano. Could a car be designed for a family that can only afford a scooter, he mulled...

What would be the possible cost of such a car, [John] Griffiths [of *The Financial Times*] asked. Ratan replied that it would be around Rs 1 lakh. It was just a random number; the price of the car had not been fixed at the time. But it stuck and would go on to become the bane of the innovation by giving it the tag of a 'cheap car'. The next day, the newspaper headline spoke of Ratan's project of a 'Rs 1-lakh car'. 'The press hijacked it and turned it into the world's cheapest car,' recalls Noel Tata.

2012-16 Trust Deficit

The trust deficit between Tata Trusts and Tata Sons inevitably strained relations between Ratan and Mistry as well. It led to the new chairman taking unilateral decisions and keeping the Tata Sons board in the dark about some important issues....Mistry's handling of certain important issues, such as the strategy to be followed in the case of Tata Steel's loss-making UK segment, became particularly contentious. Differences of perception also arose on how to handle the Tata Docomo issue, Tata Power's Indonesian mines, the future of the Nano, and some Indian Hotels assets bought in India and abroad, which were sold at a loss. The composition and functioning of the General Executive Council (GEC) created by Mistry further widened the chasm.

2022 The Return of the Maharaja

When the Air India proposal was discussed with Ratan, he 'did not show excitement', nor did he say, 'somehow we should do it', says Chandrasekaran. But 'he was extremely supportive' and 'wanted it to happen', yet 'he did not want to force' the decision, the present chairman adds. Ratan asked Chandrasekaran, 'Can you run it as a financially viable [company]?'...

Speaking to me, he says, 'Air India meant a lot to JRD' who 'led the airline to become' one of the best in the world. Bringing it back to the Tatas was an 'extremely emotional event'. He also expresses confidence that the group will be able to turn around the airline with the right professionals chosen to manage the company. Air India would now be at the 'forefront' of world aviation, he adds. 'He [Ratan] was very emotionally happy'; 'it meant a lot to him that we could get it back,' emphasises Chandrasekaran, making it clear that he too was driven to achieve the same goal. According to him, the airline is an enduring symbol of the Tatas. 'If you close your eyes and think of the Tata Group', you cannot miss the image of JRD in front of the Air India plane, he says. 'For me, it was a special moment. It was natural justice.' ■